



How can you use a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram to clarify what an organization or initiative's 'outcomes' are?

It seems that it would be simple to define a government agency, provider, policy, organization or initiative's 'outcomes'. They are the things that politicians, government agencies, the board, or citizens want to happen. However, in practice, significant confusion can arise when trying to define an initiative's 'outcomes'.

This tool - Defining an Initiative's Outcomes Explainer (B14) - shows the different ways you can define an initiative's 'outcomes'. For instance, when using the 'Archery Initiative' DoView Diagram Example (B4). Its 'outcomes' could range from the lower-level 'sufficient number of arrows fired from bow' through to the higher-level 'sufficient arrows hit the bulls-eye'. Regardless of the 'level' at which outcomes are identified, some people may additionally argue that any 'outcomes' need to be limited to boxes that are currently quantifiable and/or controllable by the initiative. Obviously, this limits the boxes allowed to be regarded as outcomes.

Concern over controllability often comes from an initiative worrying about what it will be held accountable for. Sometimes an initiative attempts to limit its 'outcomes' only to boxes that it controls (despite these usually being conceptualized as 'outputs' rather than 'outcomes'). This means the initiative is in a position to make its 'outcomes' happen and that there will be no 'attribution' problem. Controllability means that the mere fact that these 'outcomes' have been measured as occurring proves that the initiative, rather than something else, has made them happen (this is described as them being 'attributable to the initiative'). However, politicians, funders, and other stakeholders may want the agency's 'outcomes' to be higher-up the DoView strategy/outcomes diagram to stop the initiative ignoring higher-level boxes because it does not see them as its 'outcomes'. One way to grapple with this issue is to use the Four Types of Contracting for Outcomes or Outputs Tool (E3).

In DoView Planning, we use a simple definition of outcomes as the 'higher-level boxes at the right-hand-end of the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram'. To refer to specific boxes you want to measure and/or attribute to an intervention, you can just mark up the particular boxes in the DoView and say 'these are the boxes I am referring to that I want to call the 'outcomes' of the initiative.' This speeds up outcomes discussions and makes them clearer and more transparent.

Source: DOVIEW PLANNING AND PRACTICAL OUTCOMES THEORY HANDBOOK (2025). DoView Planning.Org. Copyright Dr Paul W Duignan.